

Post-incident review PIR-2026-050

Search Service: intermittent timeouts

Contoso Platform Engineering. Fictional sample data.

Summary

On 27 March 2026, Search Service experienced intermittent timeouts in production (US West) for about 12 minutes. A developer in another team noticed their integration tests failing against the service. Investigation found that an external payment processor changed its response format without warning.

Impact

Users of Search Service saw intermittent timeouts for about 12 minutes. The service owner, Digital Channels, led the response.

Timeline

- 09:06 First signal received.
- 09:29 Incident declared and on-call team engaged.
- 09:48 Likely cause identified.
- 10:26 Mitigation applied.
- 10:59 Service confirmed healthy and incident closed.

What happened

Investigation found that an external payment processor changed its response format without warning.

Capacity dashboards were checked early and showed normal headroom.

There was no documented procedure for this failure mode, so responders worked it out live.

The expected load had not been tested before release.

What went well

Responders communicated clearly in the incident channel and the status page was updated within fifteen minutes of the incident being declared.

Actions

- Add a synthetic probe that exercises the affected path every minute.
- Add a pre-deployment check that validates the setting against the production baseline.
- Assign a named owner for the component in the service catalogue.